

Impact: Medium Difficulty: Easy Misuse risk: Low

CORE FORMULA

Ask if they want advice -> Wait for yes -> Give it once -> Stop

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Before giving advice, ask: 'Would it be useful to hear my view on that?' Wait for the answer. If yes, give your advice once and stop.

BEST FOR

- Coaching or mentoring relationships
- Advising friends or family on personal matters
- Situations where your advice was not requested
- Any conversation where someone is processing a problem

PHRASE BANK

Ask Permission · Before advising

- "Would it be useful to hear my view on that?"
- "Do you want input, or do you want me to just listen?"
- "Are you looking for a suggestion or just thinking out loud?"
- "I have a thought — want to hear it?"
- "Should I weigh in or would you rather work through it yourself?"
- "Do you want advice, or do you want me to hold the space?"
- "Is this a moment where input would help, or a moment where you need to talk?"

Give Once and Stop · After they say yes

- "My view is X — that is it."
- "One thought: ..."
- "I will say it once: ..."
- "My honest read is X. Take it or leave it."
- "I do not want to repeat it — but my advice is..."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Unsolicited advice immediately: 'What you need to do is...'

Better: Can I share a thought?

Best: Do you want advice on that, or would you rather think it through yourself?
2. Weak: Repeating advice they did not take

Better: I know I said this before, but...

Best: Give advice once. If they do not take it, accept their choice.
3. Weak: Framing advice as a question to smuggle it in: 'Have you thought about doing X?'

Better: You might want to consider X.

Best: Direct advice clearly labelled as advice, given once, after asking permission.

DECISION TREE

If Someone tells you about a problem and you have a solution

Ask if they want the advice before giving it.

"I have a thought on that — would it help to hear it?"

If They say no to advice

Respect it. Do not give the advice anyway.

"That is fine — I am here if you want to talk it through."

If They say yes and you give advice

Give it once. Do not repeat it if they do not take it.

"My advice is X. I will leave it at that."

If They keep coming back with the same problem and not taking your advice

Do not repeat the same advice. Ask what they are actually looking for.

"I notice we keep coming back to this — what would actually help right now?"

SCENARIOS

Friend venting about a problem you could easily solve

Ask first whether they want input or just to be heard. — "I have an idea that might help — want to hear it, or would you rather I just listen?"

Junior colleague struggling with a task

Check whether they want help or to work it out themselves. — "I can see you are working through this — do you want input, or would you rather get there yourself?"

Parent advising adult child

Ask before advising, genuinely accept no. — "I have a view on this — do you want to hear it?"

You have already given advice they have not followed

Do not repeat it. Ask what they need instead. — "I gave you my view on this last time — I will not repeat it. What are you looking for right now?"

WHEN NOT TO USE

- In emergencies where there is no time for permission — give the critical information immediately.
- In professional contexts where giving advice is literally your role (consultant, doctor, manager giving direction).
- When the permission question itself would feel clinical or awkward in a close personal relationship.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Notice the urge to advise

Notice every time today when you feel the urge to give advice. Do not give it yet — just notice.

Day 2 — Ask first

In one conversation, ask if the person wants your advice before giving it.

Day 3 — Accept no

If they say no, accept it genuinely. Do not give the advice anyway or hint at it.

Day 4 — Give once

When you give advice, say it once and stop. Do not repeat it.

Day 5 — The listening alternative

When they say they want to be heard rather than advised, practise just listening.

Day 6 — Repeated advice audit

Notice any advice you have given more than once. Stop giving it. Ask what they actually need.

Day 7 — Calibration

Was advice received better when asked for? Did accepting 'no' change the relationship? Did you repeat any advice?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I ask if they wanted advice before giving it?
- Did I genuinely accept if they said no?
- Did I give the advice once and not repeat it?
- Did I avoid framing advice as questions?
- Did I resist the urge to give advice they had not asked for?

- Did people seem more receptive to advice when they had asked for it?
- Did I offer to just listen rather than advise when that was what was needed?